

In layman's terms, a wiki can create a Web page for you without you having to fiddle around with any code

The Origin Of The Wiki

The first wiki site was developed by Ward Cunningham, who received a Master's degree in computer science from Purdue University in 1995. He was working at the Portland Pattern Repository, and he called his idea the WikiWikiWeb.

In the late 1990s, wikis were seen as a very efficient way to develop and maintain both public and private knowledge bases. This led to a number of online collaborative ventures opting to use this tool. Most notable among these was Wikipedia.

Enterprises soon followed suit, looking at the advantages provided by the tool. Very soon, tasks, project schedules and documentation, office intranets and other forms of internal communication in offices were managed using wikis. The spurt in the use of wikis saw commercial versions of the tool being offered.

The most widely used wiki software was SocialText, by a company by the same name. Based on the Kwiki software, it was one of the earliest enterprise wikis, and was available as a hosted service from the company's server, or as a package that could be installed on the client server.

Free, open source downloads of wiki software, too, were available. A few of them, such as MediaWiki, were customised to handle specific tasks including hosting video clips and audio files. Others such as Twiki and Kwiki could be customised to a large extent and worked much like a Content Management System. These tools, when installed on an office intranet, would be sufficient to take care of all resource management and knowledge management needs.

Wikis: The What And The Why

Now what exactly does a wiki do, and why is it beneficial to implement it on an office network? Putting it simply, a wiki is a tool that allows anyone to contribute, edit, and browse through content on a network or Web site. In layman's terms, a wiki can create a Web page for you without you having to fiddle around with any code. All you need to do is enter the required text after selecting the template format (just like in a blog), create links, and you have a site ready.

To create a new page or a link, most Wikis have an "Edit" or "Create" tab at the top. You click on this tab and enter the link name. Most wikis require you to enter the link as a WikiWord.

The Advantages Of Collaborative Tools

Collaborative management tools facilitate and manage group activities. These include:

- ❑ Electronic calendars (also called time management software)—schedule events and automatically notify and remind group members
 - ❑ Project management systems—schedule, track, and chart the steps in a project as it is being completed
 - ❑ Workflow systems—collaborative management of tasks and documents within a knowledge-based business process
 - ❑ Knowledge management systems—collect, organise, manage, and share various forms of information
 - ❑ Social software systems—organise social relations of groups
- Collaborative software can be either Web-based, such as UseModWiki and Scoop, or desktop systems such as CVS or RCS.




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